

UI Vs UX

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What is the difference between UI and UX?

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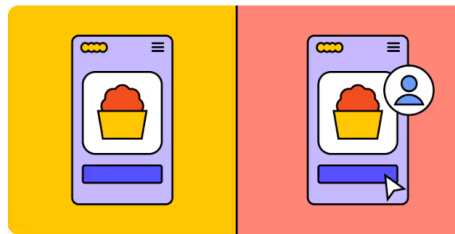
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In digital design, [user interface \(UI\)](#) refers to the interactivity, look, and feel of a product screen or web page, while [user experience \(UX\)](#) covers a user's overall experience with the product or website. Read on to find out what it takes to design engaging UI, and create a memorable UX.

Defining UI vs UX design

People sometimes confuse the two, but UI is actually a specialized subset of UX. According to Figma Designer Advocate Hugo Raymond, engaging UI lays the foundation for a positive overall user experience with a digital product or website. "Effective user interface design brings together usability and interactive design to build an emotive connection between users and products," he explains.

4 key UI design considerations

To create engaging UI, designers consider these four key elements:

1. **Page layout.** Ideally, the organization of a web page or mobile app screen should seem intuitive to users. But to organize it that way, UI designers have to make dozens of well-considered decisions—from the header position to the amount of white space.
2. **Color scheme and font selection.** UI designers carefully choose the colors and fonts on a digital product interface for consistency, accessibility, and brand alignment.
3. **Interactive elements.** From [button design](#) to drop-down menus, UI designers style digital product screens to make user flows intuitive.
4. **Wireframe and prototype fidelity.** UX designers often put together basic wireframes and prototypes. UI designers can help transform them into high-fidelity, functional, interactive product mockups

5 steps to UX design

There's more to [UX design](#) than meets the eye on a user interface. The UX design process involves market research, wireframe development, prototype testing, and cross-functional collaboration.

There are five essential steps to successful UX design:

1. Consumer and competitor research

To deliver a positive user experience, UX designers need to understand their target audience. Through UX research, they discover what their users like, what problems and pain points they're facing, and how they behave online or while using an app or software. UX designers may also perform competitor analysis using a [SWOT analysis template](#) to define their product niche.

UX designers often consolidate user research findings into [buyer or user personas](#), which are detailed descriptions of target audience types. Pro tip: with the [FigJam user persona template](#), it's easy to create and share personas with teams.

2. Information architecture

Once UX designers understand users' needs and behaviors, they can create information architecture (IA) for their product or site. Designers use IA as a visual blueprint, outlining essential navigation, content hierarchy, features, and interactions.

One key IA tool is a flowchart template, which designers use to map out key user flows and decision points. IA flowcharts help teams understand at a glance how the product is intended to work—and where there's a gap that may require additional features or updates.

3. Wireframes and prototypes

With IA sketched out, UX designers can start turning ideas into tangible models, using AI for product design to quickly explore different layouts. Teams use these proofs of concept to test ideas, define requirements, and set feature priorities. Figma's online prototypes facilitate collaboration among designers, developers, and product owners, bringing everyone together to produce a more responsive, accessible, usable, and engaging end product.

4. Testing and troubleshooting

Product mockup tools created by Figma's community of professional designers help UX designers, developers, and product owners see how features will work in practice. If testing reveals issues like confusing navigation, menus, or forms, the team can adjust them before launch.

Where do UX and UI overlap?

Scan online job listings, and you'll notice employers seeking UX/UI designers—digital designers who can fulfill both roles. This may be a stretch, but it's possible, says Hugo.

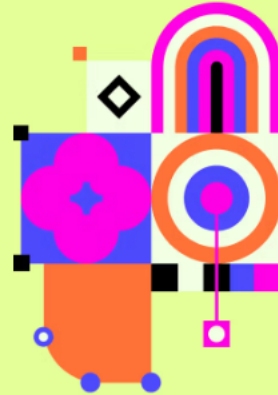
"You can work in a team where you have UI designers and UX designers as separate disciplines," he says. "But a product designer or UX designer might take on UI responsibilities, working alongside someone like a business analyst to understand all of the scenarios that need to be covered."

While UI is generally understood as a specialized subset of UX work, there are three key areas of overlap:

1. **User-centered design expertise.** Both disciplines require designers to develop empathy for the end user and consider how users want to use a product or site.
2. **Cross-functional teams.** Designers working on UI and UX must collaborate closely with graphic designers and developers to make products and sites appealing, accessible, and usable.
3. **Design tools.** UX and UI designers use many of the same tools, such as Figma's design system software, prototyping tool, UI design tool and UX design tool.

5 steps to design an app

1. Define your app idea
2. Design your app
3. Build prototypes
4. Begin development
5. Test, iterate, and launch



Step 1: Define your app idea

Every app starts with a clear idea. The more focused the concept, the easier it is to design, test, and build something that users actually want. To make sure you're headed in the right direction, it's important to validate your app idea and find a strong product-market fit.

Identify the problem or need

Start by mapping out what your app is trying to solve. Ask yourself questions like:

- What is the app's primary purpose?
- Who is it for, and what are they trying to accomplish?
- What's missing from existing solutions?
- How will this app improve that experience?
- How does this app align with the company's larger mission and values?

Getting clear on the "why" behind your idea will shape every decision that follows, from which features to build to how the interface should feel.

Conduct market research

Take a deep dive into existing apps to spot trends and identify market gaps. Knowing what's already out there will make it easier to brainstorm how to design an app with standout features and functions that set it apart.

Conducting a competitive analysis helps you understand the landscape and spot opportunities. You can also run a SWOT analysis to identify your app's strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, and potential challenges to make sure your idea stands out.

Define your target audience

Good design starts with understanding your users. What are they trying to get done? What frustrates them? What would feel like a better experience?

Start with user interviews during the early development phase. Early feedback doesn't need to be formal—just enough to spot patterns in how people approach the problem your app addresses.

Create user personas

User personas help turn raw research into something you can design around. They represent typical users with shared behaviors, needs, and preferences. Throughout the project, you can use them to check your design decisions and prioritize features that align with real user goals.

“If you don’t know who you’re building for, then the time you invest in building and creating something will be wasted.”

— Ana Boyer, Designer Advocate at Figma

Step 2: Design your app

Once the concept is solid, the next step is turning it into a functional design that balances both user interface (UI) and user experience (UX) design.

UI design covers everything your user interacts with—interactive elements like buttons and menus, as well as icons, colors, and overall layout. UX design ensures the experience is smooth and intuitive by organizing content effectively and anticipating user needs.

“When something is more attractive, compelling, and clear, people tend to gravitate towards it.”

— Katie Dill, Head of Design at Stripe

Outline core functions and features

Every feature should connect back to your app's primary goal. If it doesn't support a user task or improve the experience, it's probably not needed—at least not in the first version.

Here are a few common features that often show up in mobile apps:

- Push notifications
- Location and GPS services
- Payment and checkout flow
- Search and filtering
- Social media integrations
- Order tracking
- In-app support
- Language options
- Ratings and reviews
- Gamification elements
- Personalization based on user behavior